TG3D Possum box assembly instructions

These instructions are for both the Brushtail and Ringtail models.

The TG3D possum box is a strong, robust animal home. The box is constructed of “C/D” grade 12mm plywood. The “C” side (the better quality side) is on the outside of the box to simplify painting. Also possums don’t seem to care about surface finish. There will be marks and occasional top surface knots on the material which will not affect the functionality or durability of the box. Plywood is dimensionally stable and the box should slot together however a tiny bit of “encouragement” might be needed. The CNC cut is designed to be tight to assist in excluding water from the joints..

The box is machine cut using a “Computer Numeric Control” (CNC) router. This provides accurate joins and makes the boxes simple to assemble. It is screwed, not nailed, for strength, durability and water resistance. The screw holes are pre-drilled.

A feature of the box is a separate “mount” which helps get the 3.4Kg brushtail version into position. The mount can be screwed in, straps attached to the mount or using the supplied rope holes.

The kit is supplied with sufficient screws to assemble the box and the mount. You will need to supply mounting hardware however two type 17 screws about 50mm long would hold it in a tree.

Tools required.

- #2 Phillips head screwdriver. A power screwdriver will make this job faster however make sure you turn the torque settings down. This also allows you to “set” the screws more accurately. Flush with the top surface is sufficient.
- Sandpaper. 80 grit should be sufficient. Use this to sand the completed box prior to painting. A small orbital sander works well if you have one but hand sanding won’t take long. I give the external surfaces a basic sand before dispatch.

Parts

The box is supplied with the following parts

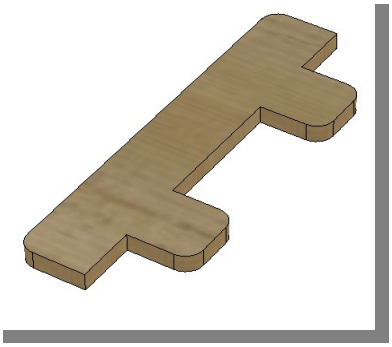
- Front - identified by the TG3D logo
- Base
- Perch - this is assembled into the front first
- 2 sides - there is a left and a right side. The front edge is the small edge
- Back
- Top
- Mount
- 2 Mount arms
- 55 6G x 20mm screws – there should be some spare.

Assembly

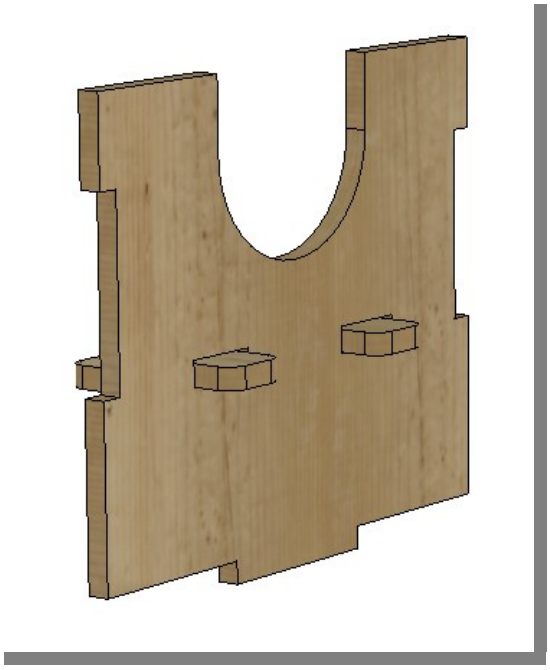
Start with the front. Remember that timber can have minor warps although plywood is normally dimensionally stable. The next step is the front and perch on the possum boxes



Take the perch and push the 2 tabs, from the front face, into the matching slots on the front. Turn the front over and put in the 2 screws, from the back, to secure it into the front. The tabs should protrude as they provide a step to help juveniles leave the box.

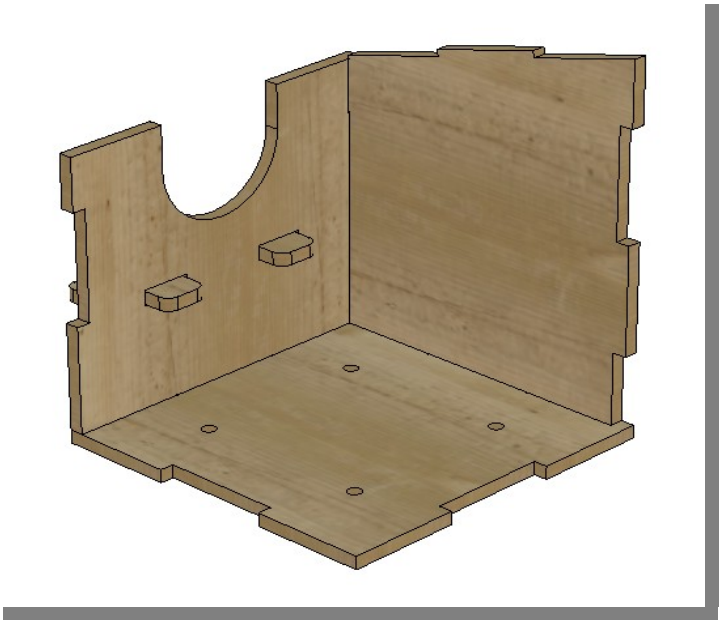


The view from the rear (internal) should look like



Next step is the base. Place the “C” (better) side face down on the bench. I find this easier to assemble on the side edges. Place the side of the front on your bench, then place the back on one side, they are identical so it doesn’t matter and then offer the front up to the base and push the tab into the slot. Place a screw in the pre-drilled hole but do not tighten it fully. Place the other screws in the base and start to tighten. Use your fingers to align the edges and it should all pull together.

The next step is the sides. It doesn’t matter which one you choose. The possum motif is designed to go on the outside. Again, put the front and base on they sides and offer the side up to the base and front. The tabs will engage with the slots.



Place a screw in the side and engage the front, repeat for the base. Look to use the screws to pull the box together. Once you have the side aligned, put the rest of the screws that intersect the base and front in and start to tighten. The joints should close up. Remember to flip the box up and put the screws in from the base as well. At this point the construction should be getting more rigid.

The next step is the opposite side. Repeat the above procedure, again progressively tightening the screws to pull the joints together.



The next piece is the back. The slots go towards the top of the box. Once again, fit the back and progressively tighten the screws. Remember the screws in the base that secure the

front, sides and back as well.



Before you secure the top, lightly sand the front at its top as it is harder to access once the top is secured. Next step is the top. It should pop into place overhanging the entrance hole. Engage the 2 “tabs” in the top of the sides with the slots cut in the underside of the top. There are 4 screws holding the top on. These screws will allow you to easily remove the top for cleaning. Just unhook the box from the mount, pop the screws out and invert the box.



The final step is the mount. Place the mount arms into the slots in the back of the box to assist in alignment. They go into the slots and are pushed up to engage the “hook” portion on the arms. Place the mount on the two arms as shown and check for alignment. There are 3 screws in the back of each arm.



At this point the box is assembled. Congratulations! Check all the sides for missing screws, there are 50 of them! I include a few extra screws so don’t be concerned about having 3 extra.

Finishing

Give the box a light sand and paint it in your desired colour. Paint the mount too.

2 coats of quality exterior grade paint to all outside surfaces will prolong the life of the box. We recommend “Dulux Weathershield”. Check with your local possum on colour preferences. Paint the box once assembled. Do not paint the inside. Possums aren’t super fussy about interior decor however they probably shouldn’t be chewing on the paint.

Mounting

Locate the box as high as you can safely in a shaded area that doesn’t receive full sun in summer. An east to south orientation is best. North and west means the possum may abandon the box during summer as it gets too hot. If you have purchased the Ringtail version, put some coconut coir into the box to emulate the traditional ringtail drey. Brushtails might appreciate a bit as well.

The mount is optional but the box weighs 3.4 kg (for the Brushtail) and the mount, which weighs 500gm, makes mounting much easier. There are a couple of options depending on location etc.

A. Use some type 17 screws and pre-drill the mount for these. Screw the mount to the tree/post/wall and drop the box on to the mount.
B. There are 2 holes in the mount arms. Use some rope to secure the mount to the tree. Hang the box on to the mount. You might need to consider a bottom brace, under the box against the tree.
C. Steel straps. Use some straps similar to bracing straps used in building. Loosen the screws holding the arms to the mounts and pop the arms back (about 2mm) so put the straps under the arms. Tighten the screws again. Using the straps, secure the mount into the tree and then drop the box on to the mount.

If you or your possum enjoyed making or living in this box, please give me a like or follow at

https://facebook.com/tg3ddesign

I'd appreciate a review and perhaps a picture of your completed box , if possible, as well.

Thanks in advance,

Tony

Note: a full colour version of this manual is available at

https://tg3d.com.au/resources

tglynn@hotmail.com